

DELHI The Congress party, in all its wisdom, has decided against fielding chief ministerial candidates for the coming state elections. Unlike the BJP, which always names its candidate for the top job in any election, central or state, the Congress prefers to wait till the elections are over.

Despite this, some contenders are clearly ahead of the others. Sheila Dikshit as the sitting chief minister has a natural advantage over her rivals. Moreover, Congressmen say that even with a 10-year anti-incumbency against her, she is still the party's best face in Delhi. In Rajasthan, former chief minister Ashok Gehlot is the unofficial mascot of the party. A sitting MLA, he is contesting the elections again.

Another ex-chief minister, Ajit Jogi, too seems to have scored over his rival, the itinerant V.C. Shukla in Chhattisgarh.

Names of the Game

SIPRA DAS

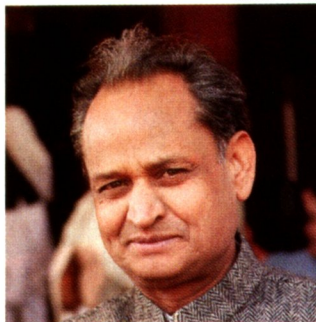


SAXENA SHARAD

Jogi has the support of a large chunk of the state MLAs. The BJP regards him and not Shukla as the main threat and has focused its campaign against Jogi.

In neighbouring

HEMANT CHAWLA



RAVI S SAHANI

Madhya Pradesh, however, former chief minister Digvijay Singh is not a contender. He is needed at the Centre to mentor Rahul Gandhi. Instead, Singh has thrown his weight behind Union

FRONTRUNNERS:
(Clockwise from left)
Dikshit, Gehlot, Nath, Jogi

minister Kamal Nath, who is the tallest leader in the state. State unit chief Suresh Pachouri is no match for BJP's Shivraj Chauhan who became chief minister in November 2005. Hence the need to pitch a strong candidate and Nath has emerged as the frontrunner.

The Congress, it seems, has quashed the hopes of younger contenders in throwing their weight behind stalwarts Dikshit and Nath. In Delhi, Ajay Maken would have wanted to be chief minister, but had to cede to Dikshit. In Madhya Pradesh, Nath has left Arjun Singh's son Ajay and scion of the Scindias, Jyotiraditya, behind. Of course, within the Congress no decision is final until Sonia Gandhi clicks the remote.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Government is mulling over the dates of the next general elections. Depending on the Congress's performance in the state polls due next month, these could be forwarded to February instead of April.

VOICES



"I've been sincerely pursuing the middle way approach in dealing with China for a long time but there hasn't been any positive response. I have given up."

Dalai Lama, Tibetan spiritual leader

"I do not like the term yuvraj. I am completely against it and against monarchical ideas. I am just a common soldier of the Congress party."

Rahul Gandhi, Congress general secretary

"No government has lost credibility so rapidly as the Manmohan Singh Government did in four months since the sordid goings on to manufacture a majority in the trust vote."

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary

"The ethnic strife in Sri Lanka is a 40-year-old struggle. It cannot be solved in just four days."

M. Karunanidhi, Tamil Nadu chief minister

"We don't respect him (Adam Gilchrist). He pretends to be a saint and people say he walks when he nicks, but why does he appeal when batsmen don't nick?"

Harbhajan Singh, cricketer

